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23 blasts in 2 days

54 dead **221** injured

494 killed in 3 years

All metros on high alert

■ By Uday Mahurkar

Terrorists have left a deadly trail across India in recent years, but last week's attacks on successive days in Bangalore and Ahmedabad followed by Surat's narrow escape from more scenes of carnage were truly terrifying in terms of their scope, planning and implications. They represent the most serious threat to democracy and nationhood since Independence. For the first time, the fear was not just confined to the targeted city but was felt all across India. In terms of the death toll—54 killed and 221 injured in Ahmedabad and Bangalore—there have been worse terror strikes but the serial blasts in Ahmedabad alone were chilling in terms of the modus operandi and the message they sent to the Central and state governments as well as the police and security forces tasked with countering the terror menace. For the first time, the terrorists planted bombs in the hospitals that were most likely to receive victims from the explosions elsewhere, displaying a new level of brutality.